

CHAPTER TEN

The Lie Marcus Almost Told

In mid-November, Marcus almost told a lie that would have, if he had told it, taken him two years to put down.

He did not tell it.

The not-telling was the work.

Here is what happened.

Marcus had been applying to colleges. He had been writing essays and supplementals and recommendations and the rest. He had been sitting at his kitchen table, most nights, with his laptop and his snack and his half-watered-down attention.

One night in mid-November, he was working on a supplemental essay for the state university he was almost certainly going to attend. The supplemental had a particular question. It said: Describe a time you have demonstrated leadership. 400 words.

Marcus had read this question fifteen times. He had stared at his blank document. He had started, three times, to write about a thing he could write about — coaching the youth basketball league at the community center, which he had done for two summers. He had stopped, three times, because the thing about coaching the youth basketball league was that it was kind of small. It was sixty hours total. It was, he knew in his heart, not exactly leadership. It was being a teenager who showed up and helped with kids. The two were related. They were not the same.

He could feel the temptation rising.

The temptation was to write the coaching thing as if it had been bigger than it had been. To use slightly grander words. To imply, without saying outright, that he had organized the program rather than that he had helped with it. To suggest, without ever quite lying, that he had been more of a leader than he had been.

He sat with the temptation for maybe twenty minutes.

He could feel — in his chest, in his stomach — the warm pull of the small lie. The way it would round the essay into a better essay. The way it would maybe nudge him slightly up in the admissions reader's eye. The

way it was, in some sense, what everyone else was probably doing — every kid he knew was making his summer activities sound bigger than they had been. He would be a fool not to.

He sat with it.

Then he thought about his dad.

His dad — Reggie Davenport, age fifty-two, who has worked at the same insurance company for twenty-six years and who has, in those twenty-six years, never once lied on his time sheet — his dad had said something to him in third grade that he had remembered. Marcus had been eight. He had just told his parents about the bike. His dad had said Marcus, you just did, at eight, what I have not figured out how to do in thirty-three years. You are not behind. You are ahead. Way ahead. Marcus had been ahead since he was eight.

If he wrote this essay with a small lie embedded in it, he would not be ahead anymore.

He would be — he could feel it as he sat there — behind. He would be a kid who had spent ten years working on telling the truth and who, in a moment of admissions-essay pressure, had let it slip. The slipping would not be visible to any reader. It

would be visible to him. He would carry it. He closed the laptop.

He stood up.

He went outside. He walked around the block.

It was a cold night. There was frost on the lawns. He could see his breath. He walked the long way around — three blocks instead of one — and he thought, the whole time, about his choices.

He could write the essay with the small lie. He would probably get in to the school. He would, six years from now, still be carrying the small lie. He would be the kid who, when he thought about his college admissions essay, would think I rounded that one up. The school never knew. The carrying would be small. It would be there.

Or he could write the essay honestly. He would write about helping with the basketball league, not leading it. He would let the essay be smaller and truer. He would probably also get in to the school — the school's admissions standards were not so tight that an honest 400-word essay would have hurt him. He would, six years from now, look back at the essay and think I told the truth even when nobody would have known. He would not carry it. He would have nothing to carry.

He stopped walking, halfway around the block. He stood under a streetlight. He breathed.

He thought — okay. Okay. I am going to write the honest one. Not because somebody is going to find out about the lie. Because I would find out about the lie. I would know. I am the audience for the rest of my life. The rest of my life is the long audience. I am not going to give the rest of my life a small lie to carry.

He finished the walk.

He went home.

He sat at the laptop.

He wrote the essay.

The essay said, more or less, this. I have spent two summers helping with the youth basketball league at our community center. I was not the head of the program. I was one of about six high school students who showed up to help with the seven- and eight-year-olds who came to play. The leadership I learned over those summers was not the organizing kind. It was the smaller kind. It was learning how to be a person a small kid trusts. It was learning that, for a seven-year-old, leadership often looks like the older kid who notices when you are about to cry and pulls you aside. That is the kind of leadership I am going to keep practicing. I do not yet know how to organize a program. I am going to learn. For now, I know how to notice. That is where I am starting from.

He read it.

It was not, by traditional admissions-essay standards, a great essay. It did not have the big I founded a nonprofit energy that the strongest essays often had.

It was, by Marcus's standards, a true essay.

He hit submit.

He closed the laptop.

He went to bed.

He slept easily.

In the morning, he told Sofia about the choice he had almost made and the choice he had made instead. He did not make a big thing of it. He told her at lunch, in passing, because Sofia is the kind of person you can tell things like that to.

Sofia said, Marcus. Of course. You did the right thing.

Marcus said, I almost didn't.

Sofia said, I know. The almost-not is the work. The doing is the result of the work.

Marcus said, Where did you learn to say things like that.

Sofia said, From Ms. Calloway. From you. From the cohort.
From practicing.

He laughed.

They ate lunch.

Three weeks later, Marcus got into the state university. The acceptance letter came in early December. His mother cried at the kitchen table. His father shook his hand the way his father did, formally, with one hand on Marcus's shoulder, and said we are very proud of you, son.

Marcus did not tell anybody, ever, that he had almost lied on the essay. The not-lying was private. The not-lying was for him. He thought about it, occasionally, in the years after.

He thought about it the first time he wrote a paper in college and was tempted to round up a small statistic. He did not round it up. He thought about it the first time he had a job interview where the interviewer asked him about a project and he was tempted to imply he had done more of it than he had. He did not imply.

He thought about it, many times, across the next thirty years, in small moments where he could have rounded the truth up and nobody would have noticed except him. He did not round.

The architecture of I would know had been built in him from age eight. The architecture had been tested, and reinforced, and tested again, and reinforced again. By eighteen, the architecture was as much a part of him as the shape of his face.

This is what twelve years of practice gives a person.

This is what Marcus is.

You should know, before this chapter ends, what happened with the Aaliyah lie. He had told his parents at eight. He had

spent third through fifth grade letting the Aaliyah thing visit him, less and less often, the way Ms. Calloway had taught him to do. By eighth grade, the visits had stopped almost entirely. By tenth grade, he had not thought of the Aaliyah lie in months. By senior year, he thought of it once a year, on

August 14th, which was the anniversary of the bike. On August 14th, he bought Aaliyah ice cream. He did not tell her why. Aaliyah, fifteen, sometimes wondered why her brother bought her ice cream on a random Tuesday in August every year. She did not ask. She figured he had his reasons. She ate the ice cream.

Aaliyah will, fifteen years from now, ask Marcus what the August 14th thing is.

Marcus will tell her.

She will say, Marcus. You have been buying me ice cream on August 14th for twenty-three years because of something you did when you were six?

He will say, Yes.

She will say, That is sweet. And also a little crazy.

He will say, I know.

She will hug him.

But that is twenty-three years away.

For now, in November of senior year, Marcus is at his kitchen table. He has just hit submit on an essay that is small and true. He is going to sleep well. He is going to go to college next August. He is going to be okay.

The cohort is going to be okay.

This is Part Two.

This is the part of the year where the kids of Room 207 are not going to do anything dramatic. They are not going to make big choices. They are just going to live — through the winter, through the cold, through the small daily choices that, added

up, become the people they become. The architecture is being built one un-told lie at a time.

The architecture is being built one un-spoken truth at a time. The architecture is being built one small ordinary night, in a kitchen, with a kid choosing not to round up.

This is the work.

This is the work that does not look like work.

This is the work that does not get noticed.

This is the work that, if you do it enough, builds a person you can live with for the rest of your life.

Marcus did it.

The cohort, in pieces, is doing it.

You, reader, are doing it too — in your own ways, on your own nights, in your own small choices that nobody is watching except you. You are the audience for the rest of your life.

The rest of your life is the long audience.

Be a person you can live with.

That is the chapter.